and then took a taxi back to the hotel. While paying the taxi driver my finger got stuck in the glass of the window and I fell to the ground in severe pain. The taxi driver was alarmed but Anjali assured him that it was not his fault and told him to carry on. After a few painful minutes I finally managed to walk back to the hotel.

India in Australia, November 2003–February 2004

So far, 2003 had turned out to be a good year for Indian cricket. Making the World Cup final was something to be proud of, but there were still plenty of challenges ahead. We were due to play a Test series against the world champions in Australia at the end of the year and that tour was to be followed by one to Pakistan in early 2004.

Before leaving for Australia we played a one-day tri-series at home against Australia and New Zealand in October and November 2003. I was in good form and scored a couple of hundreds on the way to the final. Though we lost to Australia at Eden Gardens, I came away from it feeling confident of doing well in front of big Australian crowds.

Unfortunately my series Down Under started in the worst possible fashion at the Gabba on 4 December 2003. I lasted just three balls and was given out lbw to Jason Gillespie when the ball struck the top flap of my pad. I thought it would have gone over the stumps by six inches or more and I was disappointed to see the umpire raise his finger. Sourav and VVS Laxman managed to steady the ship, and Sourav, captaining India for the first time in Australia, duly played one of his finest Test innings. His 144 at Brisbane helped to set the tone for the series. At the end of the day's play he was ecstatic and had every reason to be so.

The first Test was drawn and we moved to Adelaide for the second Test on 12 December. The Adelaide wicket was good for batting and the Australians made the most of their opportunity. When they scored 400 runs on the first day, I clearly remember the Australian team standing up on the dressing-room balcony and cheering the batsmen off the field. Day two started better for us and, with Anil bowling beautifully, we managed to restrict Australia to 556 in their first innings. With the good batting conditions and a lot of time still left in the match, there was every chance we could make a contest of it if we batted well enough.